

Before you go on camera

Getting ready for an important video conversation

Video podcasts

Job interviews

Virtual care

Suggestions from my work in media, coaching, communications, medicine and leadership.

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Treat it like the real thing

Give it the weight of an in-person meeting.

A video interview, appointment or recording is the meeting itself, not a rehearsal for one. The other person is forming impressions just as they would across a desk.

Arrive a few minutes early.

Join early enough to settle in, the way you would arrive before an in-person conversation.

Give it your full attention.

Turn on Do Not Disturb on your computer and phone, so alerts don't chime or pop up while you are sharing your screen. Close other windows and tabs. People can tell when your eyes drift to another screen.

Camera position

Get the camera to eye level.

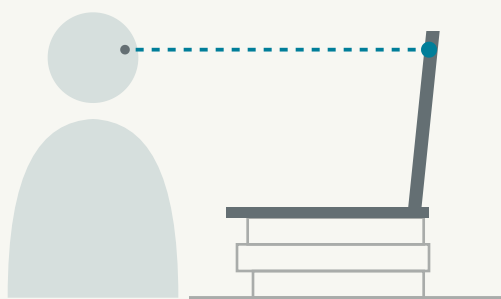
You should be looking straight ahead. Raise your laptop on a stable stand or a few books if needed. Looking slightly up into the camera is preferable to looking down.

Check the frame.

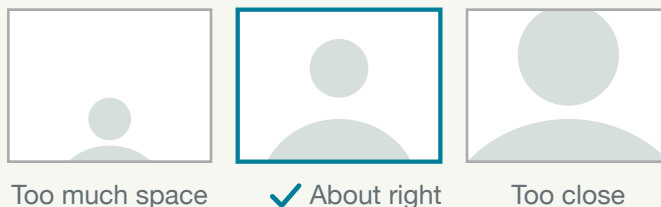
Leave a little room above your head and include your shoulders. Sit where you can stay comfortable through the conversation.

Check where you are looking.

Look at the camera as well as the person on screen. If their video window sits below the lens, move it closer to the camera when you can.



Lens at eye level; books work as a stand



Lighting and background

Put soft light in front of you.

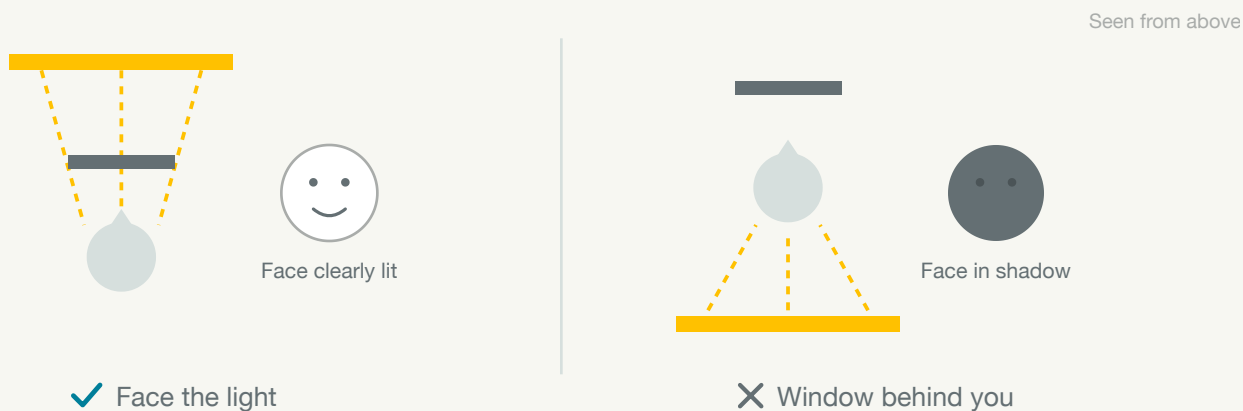
Try facing a window or using a lamp near the camera. Check the preview: can you see your face clearly?

Look behind you.

A bright window behind you can leave your face in shadow. Tidy or blur the background, then check what remains visible.

Check reflections.

If you wear glasses, look for glare. Try moving the light or adjusting its angle before changing anything else.



Sound

Choose a quiet room.

Close the door and windows. Fans, heating vents and appliances are easy to stop noticing, but the microphone still picks them up.

Soften the room.

Hard walls and bare floors create echo. A rug, curtains, a bookshelf or upholstered furniture nearby will absorb sound.

Consider headphones and a microphone.

Earbuds or headphones keep the other person's voice from echoing back through your microphone. An external microphone placed close to you usually sounds better than the one built into a laptop.

Clothing, glasses and accessories

Solid colors are an easy choice.

Fine stripes and intricate patterns can produce a rippling or shimmering effect on camera, called moiré.

Try the whole outfit on camera.

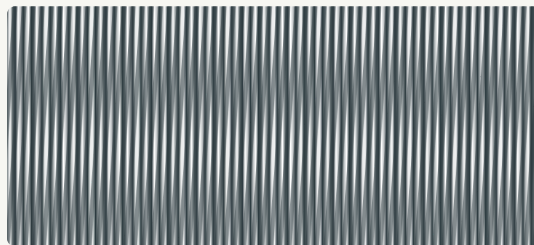
Check how your clothing and accessories look against the background. Notice whether jewelry makes noise when you move.

Choose something comfortable.

Wear something that reflects your personal style. If you use makeup, a light application of powder can reduce shine.



✓ Solid colors read cleanly



✗ Fine stripes can shimmer (moiré)

Practice beforehand

Use the setup you plan to use.

Sit in the same place, at a similar time of day, wearing your intended outfit.

See yourself as others will.

Use the FaceTime camera or the “Meet Now” option on Teams to practice. Check the frame, the light and what sits behind you.

Say a few sentences aloud.

Record a short test and play it back. Listen for volume, echo, background noise and anything rubbing against the microphone.

Before you join

- ☐ Camera at eye level or slightly above
- ☐ Face clearly lit
- ☐ Background checked
- ☐ Room quiet, headphones ready
- ☐ Clothing comfortable and tested on camera
- ☐ Camera and microphone selected
- ☐ Short recording watched and heard
- ☐ Notifications silenced